

Chapter 12: The Silence He Leaves Behind

The first day without Austin felt normal.

Jenny told herself it should feel normal.

The restaurant was the same.

Noise.

Heat.

Orders shouted across the kitchen.

Bao talking too much.

Madam Chen correcting everything.

Nothing had changed.

And yet...

Something was missing.

Jenny hated that she noticed it so quickly.

"Table four needs extra soup," Bao said.

"I know," Jenny replied automatically.

But her eyes drifted to table seven.

Empty.

Same seat.

Same view.

Empty.

She turned away.

Hard.

"Stop it," she whispered to herself.

Bao leaned over the counter.

"Stop what?"

"Nothing."

"You keep looking at table seven."

"I'm checking cleanliness."

Bao smirked.

"Of course you are."

Jenny grabbed a tray.

"I don't care if he's here or not."

"Who?"

Jenny stopped.

Slowly.

"...You know who."

Bao grinned wider.

"I didn't say anything."

"You were thinking it."

"That's not illegal."

Jenny walked away before she said something worse.

But she still felt it.

The absence.

Too loud.

Two days passed.

Then three.

Still no Austin.

Jenny told herself she was relieved.

Less tension.

Less arguing.

Less distraction.

But her thoughts didn't agree.

She noticed things she never noticed before.

The way customers sat at table seven and didn't feel right there.

The way the window felt too empty.

The way she kept expecting the bell to ring.

It didn't.

And that annoyed her more than she expected.

On the fourth day, Madam Chen approached her.

"You're distracted," she said.

"I'm not."

Madam Chen raised an eyebrow.

"You dropped a plate yesterday."

Jenny frowned.

"...It was slippery."

"And you forgot an order."

Jenny sighed.

"Okay. I'm a little tired."

Madam Chen studied her.

Then said,

"He hasn't come back."

Jenny froze slightly.

"...Who?"

Madam Chen didn't smile.

"Don't play that game with me."

Jenny looked away.

"I don't know what you're talking about."

Madam Chen sighed softly.

"He was never just a customer."

Jenny didn't answer.

Because she didn't want to.

That evening, Jenny left later than usual.

The street outside was colder.

Quieter.

She pulled her jacket tighter and started walking.

Halfway home...

She stopped.

Because something felt wrong.

Too quiet.

Too empty.

She turned slightly.

And saw it.

A black car parked across the street.

Familiar.

Too familiar.

Her heart slowed.

Then sped up.

The door opened.

Austin stepped out.

Jenny blinked.

Once.

Twice.

"You're back," she said before she could stop herself.

Austin looked at her.

Still calm.

Still composed.

But something about him felt... different.

Tired.

Not physically.

Emotionally.

"Yes," he said.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"I thought you had a trip."

"I did."

A pause.

"And?"

"I came back early."

Jenny frowned.

"Why?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Instead, he walked closer.

Not fast.

Not slow.

Just steady.

Until he stopped in front of her.

"I told myself I wouldn't come," he said.

Jenny tilted her head.

"But you did."

"Yes."

Another pause.

Then—

"I couldn't stop thinking."

Jenny's breath caught slightly.

"That's not my problem," she said quickly.

"I know."

"Then why are you telling me?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Longer than usual.

Then said quietly,

"Because it is my problem."

Silence.

The street felt too still.

Too small.

Jenny swallowed.

"You're confusing."

"I know."

"That's not helpful."

"I didn't come back to be helpful."

That made her pause.

"...Then why did you come back?"

Austin stepped half a step closer.

Not enough to scare her.

But enough to change the air between them.

"Because," he said quietly,

"I missed this."

Jenny blinked.

"This?"

He looked at her directly.

"You."

That word landed too softly.

Too dangerously.

Jenny stepped back immediately.

"Don't say things like that."

Austin didn't move.

"Why?"

"Because you don't mean it like that."

A beat.

Then—

"How do you know?"

Jenny opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Because she didn't.

Not really.

She just didn't trust it.

Didn't trust him.

Didn't trust herself more.

Austin exhaled slowly.

"I'm not good at this," he admitted.

Jenny almost laughed.

"You think?"

A faint flicker of something like amusement crossed his face.

But it faded quickly.

"I don't usually feel... distracted," he said.

"That's your polite way of saying obsessed?"

His gaze sharpened slightly.

"Maybe."

That word hung there.

Heavy.

Real.

Jenny looked away first.

Bad habit again.

"Go home, Austin."

He didn't respond immediately.

Then—

"I am home."

That confused her.

"You live in Silver Harbor."

He shook his head slightly.

"No."

A pause.

Then softer—

"Not really."

Silence.

Jenny didn't know what to say to that.

So she didn't say anything.

Austin finally stepped back.

"I'll see you tomorrow."

Jenny frowned.

"You always say that."

"And I always do."

Then he turned and walked away.

No hesitation.

No doubt.

Just certainty.

Jenny stood there long after he disappeared into the dark street.

And for the first time...

She wondered what it would feel like if he stopped leaving at all.